

Pakistan: Proxy war with Kabul likely to intensify

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【メール原文】

Pakistan is likely backing increased anti-Taliban attacks in Afghanistan. Islamabad is still seeking ways to force the Taliban regime to rein in its P|||||||

Pakistan

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Islamabad and Kabul will keep conflict confined to proxies

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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Kabul and Islamabad will fight their escalating conflict through proxies, as neither side can afford an all-out war.

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Islamabad appears to be encouraging anti-Taliban attacks and infiltration attempts from Pakistan, including the crossing of more than 100 Islamic State Khorasan Province (ISKP) fighters into Afghanistan in September.

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Kabul is likely to become more directly involved in violence against Pakistan as suspicions grow that Islamabad is sheltering and funding anti-Taliban groups and turning a blind eye to militants crossing the border.

Pakistan is likely backing increased anti-Taliban attacks in Afghanistan. Islamabad is still seeking ways to force the Taliban regime to rein in its Pakistani affiliate, the Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP), and end support for Baloch insurgents. These groups are responsible for most of the recent attacks inside Pakistan (see: Ceasefire collapse will extend cycle of low-level conflict with Afghanistan , 6 July 2026).

While Islamabad continues to use air strikes against Afghanistan whenever there are large TTP or Baloch insurgent attacks inside Pakistan, these are expensive and tend to lead to high civilian casualties. Beyond that, they seem to have no effect on Kabul's behavior. Islamabad now appears to be relying on proxies to pressure the Taliban regime.

Claims made by anti-Taliban groups suggest that the number of attacks within Afghanistan has tripled over the last two months. This includes the assassination of senior Taliban intelligence officers. Several new militant groups, most notably the Afghanistan United Front, which is led by a former Afghan National Army general, have also emerged.

While Kabul has generically accused Pakistan of supporting such attacks, it was unusually specific in blaming Islamabad for the ISKP infiltration efforts. There is indirect evidence that Islamabad is encouraging such infiltration. Anti-Taliban groups are known to be meeting inside Pakistan, and Islamabad would have to play at least a passive role for more than 100 ISKP fighters to cross into

Afghanistan.

Islamabad's tactics to pressure Kabul will harden Taliban support for insurgents. Border skirmishing has died down, but the TTP and Baloch groups, over which the Taliban has limited influence, have continued to carry out attacks in Pakistan. The current round of violence was triggered by such attacks in mid-September. If anything, hostility to Pakistan is proving useful in keeping the various Taliban factions united at a time of considerable economic hardship.

The Taliban continues to view Pakistan as weak and lacking any great-power support; it has little interest in coming to terms with Islamabad as a result. Countries that have some limited influence on the Taliban, notably Qatar and Saudi Arabia, are much more concerned about the conflict with Iran. Beijing continues to woo the Taliban with economic benefits, recently helping restore the road link between China and Afghanistan along the Wakhan Corridor.

Neither side has the interest or capability to escalate to open conflict. The Taliban regime is likely to step up support for the TTP and Baloch insurgents. Barring some drone attacks and shelling along the border, any uptick in violence between Afghanistan and Pakistan will largely be restricted to proxies. Neither side can afford a full-scale conflict.

If anything, the economic cost of an open war has increased for both countries. Pakistan continues to contend with severe fiscal constraints, a restive political opposition at home, and increasing economic problems stemming from the Middle East conflict. Afghanistan faces even worse economic conditions, including agricultural disruptions from the El Niño effect. Use of proxies will therefore remain the preferred path for both governments.

Pramit Chaudhuri

Practice Head, South Asia

chaudhuri.ne@eurasiagroup.net

Rahul Bhatia

Analyst, South Asia

bhatia.ne@eurasiagroup.net

EG South Asia

southasia@eurasiagroup.net

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